

The Style Of Queen Elizabeth II: Elegance And Propriety [B2]

Ad aprile di quest'anno, la regina avrebbe compiuto cent'anni. Per l'occasione, la King's Gallery inaugura una mostra dedicata allo stile unico di Sua Maestà.

Born on 21 April 1926, Elizabeth Alexandra Mary Windsor grew up to become the [longest-reigning](#) monarch in British history. By the time of her death in 2022, at the age of ninety-six, she had become known worldwide for her dedication to [duty](#) and international diplomacy, and also for her unique fashion style.

ROYAL OUTFITS

As the [eldest daughter](#) of King George VI, the Queen was a public figure even before she ascended to the throne after her father's death in 1952. Throughout the seventy years she served as Queen, her style remained [timeless](#) and elegant, a visible manifestation of her royal position and personality. In her later years in particular, she became known for her distinctive presentation: vibrant, monochromatic [outfits](#) accompanied by a [matching](#) hat, white gloves, Launer handbag, and [three-strand pearl necklace](#).

GREAT ELEGANCE

On the occasion of the centennial of Elizabeth II, Speak Up contacted Hazel Clark to talk about the late Queen's sense of class and elegance and how it has evolved over time. A fashion expert, historian and author, Clark grew up in the UK and did a [PhD](#) in History of Design at Brighton University before moving to the US. Now a Professor of Design Studies and Fashion Studies at Parsons School of Design in New York City, she continues to take an interest in the British royal family. For her, Elizabeth II's public persona and [demeanour](#) can be captured in one word: **Hazel Clark (English accent): I**

think that's the word: she had 'style'. She was always very distinctive, of course, because she was a female monarch, but she definitely had style. You could tell that she was somebody who paid a lot of attention to how they looked. And of course, as we know, she was a [patron](#) of a lot of British designers and she supported British fashion from the time of the famous wedding dress designed by Norman Hartnell to her support of other British designers like Hardy Amies, et cetera. So she was really associated with the British establishment in fashion, but also her own personal style. I don't think you would say the Queen or a queen could necessarily be a fashion leader, but she was certainly reflecting the fashions of the time. People

The End of an Era: Elizabeth II (1926-2022)

La morte della Regina Elisabetta II rappresenta la scomparsa di un simbolo di altri tempi. La più longeva tra i regnanti della storia britannica, era, più che una semplice governante, l'incarnazione di un'istituzione che garantiva coesione e un senso di continuità per una società che si trova immersa in una crisi di identità. Conor Gleeson , Sarah Davison

A LOST ART

According to Clark, the Queen had an exceptional ability to appear majestic and [dignified](#) — almost untouchable — while still [coming across](#) as warm and familiar to the public. It is a balance that feels almost like a lost art today. **Hazel Clark:** I think it was very much about British [propriety](#). I mean, I do remember a few years ago when the Obamas were in the White House and that famous incident when Michelle Obama met the Queen and she put her arm around the Queen. Things that you just didn't do, you didn't touch the monarch. So there always had to be that certain sense of distance. You know, wearing white gloves when she was [shaking hands](#) a lot. I think that sense of keeping your distance while being [approachable](#), which sounds a very strange thing to say, but that sense of formality; there always had to be a certain distance and a certain formality in her bodily language, how she related physically or actually not to other people. I mean, there was that sense of British [propriety](#) and formality, which I think [is much less the case](#) nowadays in British society. Elizabeth II photographed by photographer Cecil

Beaton on Princess Margaret's wedding day in 1960. She is wearing a turquoise silk taffeta [gown](#) with a [matching](#) bolero jacket.

ACCESSIBLE STYLE

Princess Diana's fashion sense [marked a striking departure](#) from [long-held](#) royal traditions, says Clark. It broke down barriers through a far more direct and personal connection with the public. **Hazel Clark:** Diana was technically a [commoner](#). She wasn't of royal blood and she came unexpectedly to the position of marrying into the royal family when she was very young. But her style evolution was very interesting because at first she was what was called the 'Sloane ranger'. She was wearing a very particular style which was associated with upper middle-class women. But then she really evolved a sense of style, which then really moved into fashion. And also, it became more and more [confident](#) and some would say more and more [risqué](#), and particularly as the marriage was breaking down, and then with the final [split](#) with the prince, you know, the famous revenge dress.

IN HER SHOES

By contrast, as Clark notes, Catherine, the current Princess of Wales, has acquired some of the late Queen's taste for British designers and classic [heritage staples](#), while shaping a style that is distinctly her own.

Hazel Clark: I think Catherine is very interesting because she is very much next in line to the throne. I mean, in some ways it's similar to the Queen in the way that she's wearing British or Scottish labels and brands... Burberry, but also there's been collaborations recently with cashmere company Johnstons of Elgin, and with Le Kilt for [bespoke fashion](#). So she's actually moving into these small collaborations with brands which are very much British. She was, on a recent visit, wearing a [full-length kilt](#) and wearing a Fair Isle vest, which was commented upon. She's certainly [aware](#) of Diana and Diana's style and sometimes wears, for example, a tiara worn by Diana. So I get the sense that she's very conscious of that strong style presence of Diana, but has also developed her own sense of confidence, which is still very much British in the way that the Queen's was. Diana in a black dress by

Christina Stambolian, also known as the Revenge Dress. Kate Middleton wearing classic country chic, English [outfits](#) that work well at formal events and on country walks. Meghan Markle wearing a glamorous [gown](#) during the Fifteen Percent Pledge fundraising gala in Los Angeles in February 2026.

CALIFORNIAN LOOK

Meghan, Duchess of Sussex, represents a very different paradigm, Clark notes, mainly because she comes from a different cultural [background](#); something that has become even more evident since she and her family have moved back to California. **Hazel Clark:** I think that Meghan now is a sort of comfortable American since they made the decision that they were living in this country and obviously moved to the West Coast. There was something she wore a couple of days ago for a [fundraiser](#) for the Fifteen Percent Pledge, which was a [gown](#) by the designer Charles Harbison, or Harbison Studio, who's a Black designer. And the event was a [fundraiser](#) which basically supports [Black-owned businesses](#). So I think she's conscious, of course, of what she wears and how she looks. Her reference point is not just this country, but it's much more Hollywood, potentially, and glamour, and a different sort of glamour, so perhaps a little bit more [showy](#). But definitely developing her own style, but it's much more American style. She wears more American brands. She wears Oscar de la Renta, she wears Club Monaco or J.Crew, which you wouldn't find Catherine wearing that, understandably. So I think there are these different particular styles which they each now have, which are associated with themselves as individuals, their origins and where they live and where they are in the world and where they've chosen to be.

STEADY PRESENCE

The Queen's death in September 2022 left a major [void](#) in British society. After more than seventy years on the throne, her [steady](#) presence had become a source of [reassurance](#) for many. **Hazel Clark:** I must admit, even though I've lived in the United States for a long time, that it came as a sense of loss when the Queen passed away, because she had just literally always

been there, like a family member. In monarchies, people, they may or may not like the Queen or the monarch, but many people still [relate to](#) that [figurehead](#), because that's just the way the society is organised. The way she left this world was very elegant, very modest, very [unassuming](#), and that was part of her [charm](#), but conscious also that she was obviously a very [strong-minded](#) woman who had a very difficult job. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Queen Elizabeth II: Toning Outfits And Wellington Boots](#).

Glossary

- **matching** = coordinato
- **pearl necklace** = collana di perle
- **patron** = sostenitrice
- **Black-owned businesses** = imprenditoria nera
- **coming across** = dare l'impressione
- **approachable** = disponibile, alla mano
- **commoner** = cittadina comune
- **risqué** = audace
- **kilt** = gonna scozzese
- **background** = origine, contesto
- **figurehead** = figura rappresentativa
- **unassuming** = discreto
- **propriety** = decoro
- **shaking hands** = stringere la mano
- **long-held** = radicate
- **confident** = sicura di sé
- **staples** = elementi essenziali
- **gown** = abito lungo
- **showy** = appariscente
- **void** = vuoto
- **demeanour** = comportamento, portamento
- **heritage** = tradizionali
- **bespoke fashion** = moda su misura
- **outfits** = completi
- **three-strand** = a tre fili
- **PhD** = dottorato
- **split** = rottura
- **aware** = consapevole
- **dignified** = dignitosa, maestosa
- **steady** = costante, stabile
- **strong-minded** = dal carattere forte, determinata
- **fundraiser** = evento di raccolta fondi
- **reassurance** = sicurezza, conforto

- **relate to** = sentirsi legati a
- **eldest daughter** = figlia maggiore
- **is much less the case** = essere così
- **marked a striking departure** = segnò una rottura evidente
- **full-length** = lunga
- **charm** = fascino
- **longest-reigning** = che ha regnato più a lungo
- **duty** = dovere
- **timeless** = senza tempo